

Karat's fanatic opposition to the nuclear agreement is proof of his blind anti-American stance. It would be better if he asked himself this question: what does the country stand to gain by not signing the agreement.

N. VENKATESH, on e-mail

With his dogmatic attitude, Karat has been derailing most of the Centre's progressive measures. He has, however, been silent on the West Bengal Government's deviations from his Marxist ideology. This just shows that his bite has no teeth.

K.V. GOPAL, Chennai

Karat glibly holds the urban-rural divide and the concentration of wealth in a few hands responsible for the rampant poverty in the country. He advises us to change the whole trajectory of development but have the Marxists done all this during 30 years of their rule in W. Bengal? If they have, why do thousands of people still live in abject poverty on the streets of Kolkata?

SHARAD ABHYANKAR, on e-mail

The magazine writes, "his dogmatic consistency has influenced governance". Consistency is the last thing CPI(M) is concerned about. They support and oppose the Government at the same time. Their alliance with the Congress is plain opportunistic. The party just wants to enjoy power without any responsibility.

S.S. SINGH, Delhi

The story gives an impressive line-up of people ("And Then There Were", December 24) but it would have been better if Newsmakers 2007 had been some lesser

known but equally important achievers.

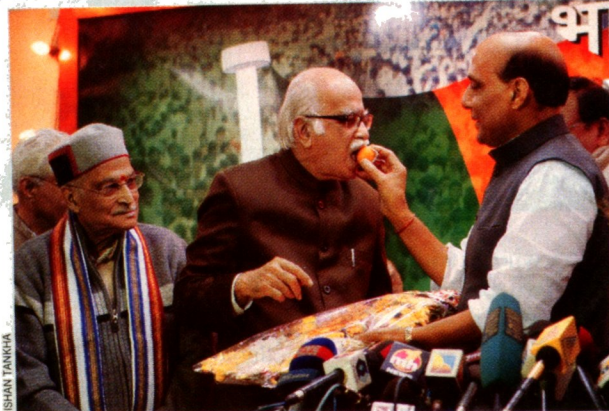
SARITA BERY, Bangalore

Licence to Kill

The government should withdraw all the gun licences that have been issued so far ("Rule of the Gun", December 17). Issuing a gun licence is equivalent to giving the right and power to kill another person, without going through the legal channel.

C.E. GOPALAKRISHNAN, Pudukcherry

IN MODERATE GARB



Things have come a full circle for L.K. Advani ("Candidate Advani", December 24). The gamble that he took by praising Jinnah, which came under sharp attack two years ago, has finally paid off well. Even when he had been the home minister in Atal Bihari Vajpayee's cabinet, his sole agenda had been to shape himself into the former prime minister's mould to gain acceptability. And he has succeeded.

SAMEER MOHINDRU, Kuala Lumpur, Malaysia

If Advani becomes the prime minister of the country, the possibility of another Partition cannot be ruled out.

With his Hindutva ideology in a secular country like India, he will be a misfit as the prime minister. The desecration of the Babri Masjid under his command is still fresh in one's memory. Had the law been strict with him, he would have long seen the twilight of his career.

K. PRADEEP, Chennai

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Correction

In our review of *Unsung* ("Humble Heroism", November 26) we had stated that... "journalist Anita Pratap gets top billing but writes only a brief introduction." Both Pratap and photographer Mahesh Bhatt who published the book have confirmed that Pratap did indeed travel extensively and all the text contained in the book was written by her. The error is regretted.

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Years Ago in India Today

JANUARY 16-31, 1978



Divide to Rule

If 1977 was born under the auspices of disparate parties joining together to form a united Janata Dal, the New Year of 1978 has been ushered in by Mrs Gandhi giving brand to her own brand of Congress, the harbinger of political fragmentation, putting a dangerously

severe strain on the delicate fabric of the far-flung Republic of India. Thirty years ago, days before his martyrdom, Mahatma Gandhi had written out a new draft constitution for the Congress, which stated that "the Congress in its present shape and form, as a propaganda vehicle and a parliamentary machine, has outlived its use". Today, Gandhi's warning about the dangers of confining politics to propaganda and parliamentary machine rings clear and true. After Independence, the Congress ceased to be an organ of struggle for national advance; it became the tool for retaining power.

—Nilhil Chakravarty

